the Civil War, remarked Kennedy when presented with the estimate. He then added: “And we have not gotten over that in a hundred years.”[19]

Kennedy had to respond to Khrushchev’s challenge without increasing tensions that might produce all-out war, to which the Soviet leader had said the Cold War was only a prelude. So far, he had failed to carry through the invasion of Cuba planned by President Eisenhower, signaled readiness to compromise with the Soviets on Laos against his predecessor’s advice, and suffered public humiliation in Vienna. Kennedy had to do something to change both Khrushchev’s perception and, more important, that of his opponents at home, who saw him as a weak president, potentially disastrous for the country. Resorting to the lessons he had drawn from his Harvard thesis on Britain’s lack of preparedness for World War II, the president made a public show of getting ready for war.

On July 25, Kennedy made his way on crutches to the White House to deliver a speech about the growing Berlin crisis. He told the television audience that he was prepared to stand up to the Soviet bully. Four days earlier, Congress had authorized more than $12 billion for new aircraft, missiles, and ships that Kennedy had requested earlier. Now he called for additional defense spending of $3.25 billion and 90,000 more recruits for the navy and air force. It was a drastic increase in military spending and a dramatic departure from the Eisenhower years. Kennedy’s message was that America was not going to sleep, as Britain had done before the war. It was going to arm itself to the teeth.

“We do not want to fight,” declared the president, “but we have fought before. And others in earlier times have made the same dangerous mistake of assuming that the West was too selfish and too soft and too divided to resist invasions of freedom in other lands. Those who threaten to unleash the forces of war on a dispute over West Berlin should recall the words of the ancient philosopher: ‘A man who causes fear cannot be free from fear.’ ”[20]

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